

PHILOSOPHY

What Can We Know About Morality?

An Introduction to Moral Epistemology

*Based on Richmond Campbell, 'Moral Epistemology',
Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy (Summer 2024 Edition)*

Lower Sixth & Upper Sixth Philosophy | Pre-Reading Resource

Introduction: The Problem at the Heart of Ethics

Guiding Question: *How is moral knowledge possible at all?*

When we say that torturing animals for fun is wrong, or that we ought to help someone in genuine need, we are making moral claims. But here is a pressing philosophical question: are these claims things we can actually know? And if so, how?

This question is the central concern of moral epistemology — a field that sits at the intersection of ethics (what is morally right or wrong?) and epistemology (what is knowledge, and how do we acquire it?). Unlike asking simply what we ought to do, moral epistemology asks a prior question: can we ever be in a position to know what we ought to do?

This might seem like an obvious 'yes'. But when we look more carefully, at least six serious clusters of problems threaten to undermine the very possibility of moral knowledge. This guide walks you through each of them, offering the key arguments on both sides.

A Note on the Definition of Moral Knowledge

Throughout this guide, moral knowledge is understood — following the standard philosophical convention — as justified true moral belief. This means that to know something morally, you must:

(1) believe it, (2) that belief must be true, and (3) you must be justified in holding it. This is called the JTB (Justified True Belief) account of knowledge.

Key Terms at a Glance

Epistemology	The branch of philosophy concerned with the nature, sources, and limits of knowledge.
Moral Epistemology	The study of whether and how moral knowledge is possible.
Cognitivism	The view that moral claims are genuine statements capable of being true or false.
Non-cognitivism	The view that moral claims do not express truths but rather attitudes, emotions, or prescriptions.
Moral Realism	The view that objective moral facts exist independently of what anyone thinks or feels.
Moral Relativism	The view that moral truths are relative to cultures, individuals, or social groups.
Moral Naturalism	The view that moral facts are natural facts, knowable through empirical study.

Section 1: Does Moral Disagreement Show That Moral Knowledge Is Impossible?

Guiding Question: *If people disagree so persistently about morality, does that prove there are no moral truths to be known?*

The Sociological Challenge

One of the most intuitive arguments against moral knowledge is drawn from the sheer breadth of moral disagreement across cultures and history. Consider how different societies have disagreed about the permissibility of slavery, the rights of women, the morality of capital punishment, or

euthanasia — often for centuries. This looks very different from, say, disagreement about scientific facts, which tends to get resolved over time through evidence.

The argument runs roughly like this: if there were genuine moral truths 'out there' to be discovered, we would expect greater convergence as people reason more carefully. The persistent and deep nature of moral disagreement suggests instead that there may simply be no moral facts to converge on. People express moral attitudes, but there is nothing they can be right or wrong about. Hence, moral knowledge is impossible.

Three Responses to the Argument

However, the argument is not conclusive. There are at least three kinds of explanation for moral disagreement that are compatible with the possibility of moral knowledge:

- Disagreement rooted in non-moral facts. People who disagree morally about, say, capital punishment often also disagree about empirical matters (e.g., does it deter crime?). If the moral disagreement is really a disagreement about non-moral facts, resolving the factual dispute might resolve the moral one.
- Disagreement due to distortions of judgement. Personal bias, ideological pressure, emotional distress, or self-interest can prevent us from reasoning clearly. This explains persistent disagreement without conceding that there is no truth to be found.
- Disagreement as parallel to complex scientific disputes. Just as scientists disagree about difficult empirical questions for decades, moralists can disagree about genuinely hard moral questions without this showing that there is no right answer.

Furthermore, it would be a mistake to exaggerate the extent of moral disagreement. There is substantial cross-cultural agreement on certain core moral values: the importance of avoiding harm to others, fairness, loyalty, and freedom. Peter Singer's famous example of rescuing a drowning toddler at minimal cost to oneself elicits near-universal agreement across all cultures.

Exam & Essay Tip: When discussing moral disagreement, always distinguish between disagreement that is irreducible (suggesting no moral facts) and disagreement that is explicable by other means (bias, ignorance, etc.). The latter does not support moral scepticism.

Section 2: Do Our Emotions and Motivations Undermine Moral Knowledge?

Guiding Question: *If moral judgements necessarily motivate us, does this mean they cannot be beliefs at all — and therefore cannot constitute knowledge?*

Hume's Psychological Challenge

The Scottish philosopher David Hume (1711–1776) mounted a powerful psychological challenge to moral knowledge. His argument proceeds from the observation that moral judgements seem to motivate us to act in a way that ordinary factual beliefs do not. If I judge that torturing animals for fun is wrong, I am thereby inclined not to do it — and to discourage others from doing so. But if I simply believe it is raining, I am not thereby motivated to do anything.

Hume's argument can be reconstructed as follows: (1) If moral knowledge is possible, some moral judgements must be beliefs. (2) Moral judgements, by themselves, necessarily motivate us to act. (3) Beliefs, by themselves, cannot motivate us — only desires can do that. Therefore, moral judgements are not beliefs. Therefore, moral knowledge is impossible.

The Debate: Internalism vs Externalism

The argument turns critically on premise (3), sometimes called 'Hume's dictum'. Philosophers divide into two camps:

- Internalists hold that the link between moral judgement and motivation is necessary and internal. To make a genuine moral judgement just is to be motivated, at least to some degree. This supports premise (2) and makes premise (3) a serious problem.
- Externalists deny that the connection between moral judgement and motivation is anything more than contingent. We happen to be socialised to care about moral matters, but a person could in principle make a genuine moral judgement without feeling any motivation. This defuses premise (2).

The Hybrid View

A promising middle-ground is the 'hybrid' conception of moral judgement, according to which moral judgements are neither purely beliefs nor purely desires, but complex mental states that normally combine both. In their primitive evolutionary form, moral responses were primarily emotional and motivational; over time, humans developed the capacity to form genuine moral beliefs. On this view, moral knowledge is possible — even if moral judgements are not always, or purely, beliefs.

Exam & Essay Tip: Hume's argument is formally valid, so the only way to resist it is to challenge one of its three premises. Identify which premise you think is weakest, and be prepared to justify your choice with argument.

Section 3: What Would Moral Facts Have to Be Like?

Guiding Question: *For moral knowledge to be possible, moral facts must exist — but what kind of facts could they be?*

The Ontological Challenge

Even if we set aside disagreement and motivation, there is a deeper challenge. Moral knowledge must be about something — there must be moral facts for us to know. But what sort of facts could these be? Philosophers have typically considered three possibilities:

(a) Theological Facts

One ancient view holds that moral facts are grounded in the will or commandments of God: something is wrong because God forbids it, and right because God commands it. This remains popular in religious traditions, but it faces two significant problems. First, it depends on settling difficult questions about God's existence. Second, and more troubling, is the dilemma first posed by Socrates in Plato's *Euthyphro*: does God forbid cruelty because it is wrong, or is cruelty wrong because God forbids it? If the former, then wrongness is logically prior to God's will, and the appeal to God's commands adds nothing. If the latter, then God's commands appear arbitrary — He could, in principle, make cruelty permissible simply by commanding it. Most theists find this unacceptable.

(b) Non-natural Facts

An influential tradition, associated with philosophers such as G. E. Moore (1873–1958) and W. D. Ross (1877–1971), holds that moral facts belong to a realm that is neither natural nor supernatural — they are *sui generis*, in a class of their own. We apprehend them through a special faculty of moral intuition, analogous to how we grasp mathematical truths. Moore's famous 'open question argument' attempts to show that no matter which natural property you identify with goodness (e.g., pleasure), it always remains an open, non-trivial question whether that property really is good. This suggests moral properties cannot be identical with any natural property.

The major objection is that moral intuitionism struggles to explain how we reliably access this non-natural realm, and why different people's 'intuitions' conflict so frequently.

(c) Natural Facts — Moral Naturalism

Moral naturalism holds that moral facts are natural facts — facts about the world that can, in principle, be investigated empirically. This view has the great advantage of avoiding the mysterious non-natural realm, placing moral knowledge on the same footing as other scientific knowledge. However, it faces a powerful objection from Kant: any attempt to derive moral conclusions from purely natural facts appears to commit what Moore called the 'naturalistic fallacy' — the illegitimate move from 'is' to 'ought'.

Contemporary moral naturalists respond that moral properties may supervene on natural properties, or even be identical with complex natural properties, in the way that biological properties supervene on chemical ones. Whether this response is ultimately successful remains one of the most contested questions in metaethics.

Exam & Essay Tip: The Euthyphro Dilemma is a classic argument that appears across philosophy of religion and ethics. Ensure you can state both horns of the dilemma and explain why each is problematic for the divine command theorist.

Section 4: Does Evolution Undermine Our Moral Beliefs?

Guiding Question: *If our moral beliefs evolved for survival rather than truth, can they constitute genuine knowledge?*

The Evolutionary Challenge

A more recent and increasingly influential challenge comes from evolutionary biology. The widely accepted view is that human moral inclinations — our tendencies toward fairness, benevolence, and loyalty — evolved because they enhanced the survival and reproductive success of our ancestors. But if this is so, our moral beliefs were shaped by natural selection rather than by tracking moral truth. Does this 'debunk' them?

Three Debunking Arguments

(a) The Argument from Parsimony

Some philosophers argue that the Darwinian explanation of our moral beliefs — in terms of genetic fitness and group selection — is simpler and better supported than the alternative explanation that our beliefs track genuine moral truths. We do not need to posit moral facts to explain why we hold our moral beliefs. This is an application of Occam's Razor: do not multiply entities beyond necessity.

(b) The Argument from Moral Objectivism

Sharon Street (2006) argues that if moral truths are genuinely objective — that is, they hold independently of all human attitudes — then it would be an extraordinary coincidence if our evolutionarily-shaped moral inclinations happened to track those truths. Evolution 'aimed' at reproductive fitness, not moral truth. So either moral truths are objective but our beliefs are unlikely to track them, or our beliefs do track something — but that something is not stance-independent moral truth. Either way, robust moral realism appears threatened.

(c) The Argument from Irrational Emotions

Drawing on moral psychology and neuroscience, some philosophers argue that our moral intuitions — the immediate, gut-level responses that drive many of our moral judgements — are products of 'System 1' thinking: fast, unconscious, and emotionally driven. Since these intuitions originated as primitive survival adaptations, they may be unreliable guides to moral truth in the complex conditions of modern life.

Responses to the Evolutionary Challenge

Each of these debunking arguments can be resisted. Moral naturalists, in particular, can argue that if moral facts are natural facts — specifically, facts about what promotes human flourishing and successful social cooperation — then it is not at all surprising that evolution produced creatures with moral inclinations that track these facts. Natural selection could have 'aimed' at fitness and hit moral truth as a by-product, if moral truth just is what promotes fitness-enhancing social cooperation.

Moreover, the claim that emotions are unreliable in moral reasoning is contested. Recent research in cognitive science suggests that emotional processing is not simply a distortion of rational thought, but plays an indispensable role in practical deliberation — including moral deliberation.

Exam & Essay Tip: Street's Darwinian Dilemma is philosophically powerful because it is a dilemma — any response must take one of its two horns. Be clear about which horn a given theorist accepts and what they sacrifice by doing so.

Section 5: How Should We Go About Acquiring Moral Knowledge?

Guiding Question: *What method, if any, can generate justified moral beliefs — and does that method yield genuine knowledge or merely moral conservatism?*

The Methodological Challenge

Even if the previous problems can be overcome, we still need to ask: by what method might moral knowledge be acquired? The history of philosophy has produced several major proposals, each with its own strengths and limitations.

(a) Naturalised Epistemology

W. V. O. Quine (1908–2000) proposed that epistemology — the study of knowledge — should be absorbed into natural science. Rather than seeking a priori foundations for knowledge, we should look to scientific psychology and cognitive science to explain how knowledge is possible. Applied to morality, this yields 'naturalised moral epistemology': the project of explaining moral knowledge using the resources of empirical science.

The difficulty is that science, as traditionally conceived, tells us how things are, not how they ought to be. Epistemology has a normative dimension — it tells us how we ought to reason. If moral epistemology is absorbed into a purely descriptive science, it risks losing the normative dimension that makes it epistemology at all.

(b) Reflective Equilibrium

John Rawls (1921–2002) proposed a method known as reflective equilibrium as the basis for justified moral belief. The idea is that we begin with our 'considered moral judgements' — those moral beliefs we hold with the greatest confidence and the least distortion — and then seek principles that systematise and explain them. When principles and particular judgements conflict, we revise either the principles or the judgements until a stable, coherent equilibrium is achieved.

A serious objection is that this method is inherently conservative: it tends to endorse the moral status quo, since it begins from whatever moral beliefs we happen to hold. Radical moral progress — like the abolition of slavery — seems to require standing outside our existing moral views and judging them wrong, not merely making them more coherent.

(c) Pragmatic Naturalism

Philip Kitcher (2011) developed a 'pragmatic naturalist' approach, drawing on the American pragmatist tradition (Dewey, James). On this view, moral knowledge is not about discovering timeless truths but about developing the 'moral know-how' to live together successfully. Moral progress occurs not through abstract reasoning from principles, but through resolving practical conflicts in ways that better serve the evolving needs of communities. The abolition of slavery,

for instance, was achieved not by applying a general principle, but by exposing and resolving the internal contradictions within moral perspectives that tolerated it.

Critics ask whether pragmatic naturalism can account for genuine moral truth, or whether it merely replaces moral knowledge with practical problem-solving.

Exam & Essay Tip: Reflective equilibrium is one of the most influential methods in contemporary political philosophy (Rawls uses it in *A Theory of Justice*). Practise explaining it clearly with a concrete example, and always pair it with the conservatism objection.

Section 6: Does the Standpoint from Which We Reason Matter?

Guiding Question: *If the standards we use to assess moral knowledge are themselves biased, can any moral epistemology be genuinely impartial?*

The Feminist Challenge and the Bias Paradox

Feminist philosophers have raised a distinctive moral challenge to epistemology itself. The traditional ideal of impartial, disinterested knowledge has, they argue, systematically marginalised the perspectives and experiences of women and other oppressed groups. For example, medical research conducted exclusively on male subjects produced theories of disease that failed to apply to women — a problem revealed only when feminist pressures broadened the research.

More radically, feminist epistemologists such as Louise Antony have identified what she calls the 'bias paradox'. Feminists want to reject certain biases (e.g., gender bias in moral theory) on the grounds that they distort the truth. But to make this critique, feminists must appeal to some conception of what the unbiased truth looks like. Yet they also want to reject impartiality as an epistemic ideal, since perfect impartiality seems impossible and potentially misleading. The paradox is that in rejecting biased standards as unjust, feminists appear to presuppose an impartial standard of justice — the very thing they are criticising.

A possible resolution: we distinguish between epistemically good biases (those that lead us toward truth, including feminist ones) and epistemically bad biases (those that distort truth). This dissolves the apparent paradox, but requires an independent account of what counts as truth — which brings us back to the broader question of moral realism.

Exam & Essay Tip: The bias paradox is a sophisticated argument that rewards careful articulation. A strong essay response will identify the paradox precisely (feminists criticise bias using what looks like a bias of their own) and then evaluate proposed resolutions.

Section 7: Is Moral Knowledge a Social Achievement?

Guiding Question: *Should we reconceive moral knowledge not as the property of isolated individuals, but as something achieved collectively through dialogue and shared reasoning?*

The Social Dimension of Moral Knowledge

Recent developments in both social epistemology and moral psychology suggest that the traditional picture of moral knowledge as the justified true belief of a single individual may be fundamentally mistaken. Psychological experiments have repeatedly demonstrated that individuals reason poorly on their own, subject to confirmation bias, motivated reasoning, and emotional distortion. Yet when people reason together in cognitively diverse groups — in which each member can challenge the proposals of others — performance improves dramatically.

The psychologists Hugo Mercier and Dan Sperber cite the abolition of slavery in Britain (1834) as an illustration. Abolitionists began in a small minority. Through free, diverse, and extended public debate — in which the moral character of former slaves was visible to all, and the economic consequences of abolition were scrutinised — public moral opinion changed. Moral knowledge, on this view, is more likely to be achieved through interactive reasoning among those with diverse viewpoints than through solitary reflection.

Moral Knowledge Embodied in Emotions

A further implication of this social view is that moral knowledge may be embodied not only in beliefs but also in the shared emotional responses of a community. The philosopher Richmond Campbell argues that a society can 'know through its feelings of guilt' that it has acted wrongly — even when its ideological beliefs tell it otherwise. This is analogous to the case of the woman who cannot shake her resentment at being passed over for promotion, even though she does not consciously believe she has been wronged. Her persistent emotional response may track a moral fact more accurately than her conscious belief.

Epistemic Exclusion

Michael Tomasello's research on the evolution of human morality suggests that moral norms emerge from 'shared intentionality' — the capacity of diverse individuals to form a common moral project in which they participate as equals. When some members of a community are systematically excluded from moral deliberation — on grounds of race, gender, class, or disability — the community's capacity for moral knowledge is thereby diminished. Miranda Fricker's concept of 'epistemic injustice' captures one dimension of this: the wrong done to someone who is denied recognition as a credible moral knower because of their social identity.

Exam & Essay Tip: The social epistemology of morality is a relatively new and rapidly growing area. Arguments here connect powerfully with questions in political philosophy and the philosophy of race and gender. Bringing these connections into an essay is a strong sign of philosophical sophistication.

Conclusion: Is Progress Possible?

Moral epistemology confronts us with six clusters of challenges — sociological, psychological, ontological, evolutionary, methodological, and moral — each posing serious difficulties for the possibility of moral knowledge. Yet for each cluster, there are avenues of response worth serious exploration. The field has not resolved these challenges, but it has made genuine progress in clarifying what is at stake and identifying the most promising lines of response.

Perhaps the most significant development in recent moral epistemology is the recognition that moral knowledge, if it is possible at all, is likely to be a deeply social and collaborative achievement. It is not the private property of the solitary moral reasoner, but the product of sustained, free, and diverse dialogue within and between communities. This has implications not only for abstract philosophy but for how we structure our institutions, our public discourse, and our education.

Questions for Further Reflection

The following questions are designed to push your thinking further. They are the kinds of questions that reward sustained reflection and that might form the basis of essay arguments.

- If someone is raised in a culture with systematically mistaken moral values, and reasons impeccably within those values, do they have moral knowledge? What does your answer imply about the relationship between moral knowledge and moral truth?
- Hume's argument concludes that moral judgements cannot be beliefs. Could one accept this conclusion and still maintain that moral knowledge is possible? What would moral knowledge look like without moral beliefs?

- Is the 'open question argument' convincing? If so, what follows for moral naturalism? If not, where does it go wrong?
- Street's Darwinian Dilemma appears to force a choice between moral realism and evolutionary debunking. Is there a third option that avoids both horns? If so, what would it look like?
- Rawls's method of reflective equilibrium has been criticised as morally conservative. Is this a decisive objection, or can the method be defended against it?
- Can a community 'know' something morally that none of its individual members knows? What would distributed or collective moral knowledge look like, and does the concept make sense?
- Is the feminist critique of impartiality self-undermining? Evaluate Antony's proposed resolution of the bias paradox.

Key Thinkers at a Glance

David Hume (1711–1776)	Argued that moral judgements are expressions of passion, not reason; originator of the 'is-ought gap' and 'Hume's dictum'.
Immanuel Kant (1724–1804)	Argued that moral knowledge must be a priori and that moral properties cannot be derived from natural facts alone.
G. E. Moore (1873–1958)	Coined 'naturalistic fallacy'; argued via the open question argument that goodness is a non-natural, indefinable property.
W. D. Ross (1877–1971)	Defended moral intuitionism; argued we have direct, prima facie knowledge of moral duties.
W. V. O. Quine (1908–2000)	Proposed naturalised epistemology; argued epistemology should be pursued within empirical science.
John Rawls (1921–2002)	Developed reflective equilibrium as a method for justifying moral and political principles.
Sharon Street (b. 1974)	Formulated the Darwinian Dilemma, challenging moral realism on evolutionary grounds.
Philip Kitcher (b. 1947)	Developed pragmatic naturalism as an approach to moral epistemology.

Miranda Fricker (b. 1966)	Coined 'epistemic injustice' to describe the harms done to credibility as a moral knower.
Richmond Campbell (b. 1940s)	Author of this SEP entry; defends a hybrid, social conception of moral knowledge.

Suggestions for Further Reading

These texts vary in difficulty. Those marked (*) are particularly accessible for Sixth Form students.

- (*) Peter Singer, 'Famine, Affluence, and Morality' (1972) — a famous article raising urgent questions about moral obligation.
- (*) J. L. Mackie, *Ethics: Inventing Right and Wrong* (1977) — a clear and readable defence of moral scepticism.
- (*) Jonathan Haidt, *The Righteous Mind* (2012) — a compelling account of the psychology of moral judgement.
- Plato, *Euthyphro* — the original source of the Euthyphro Dilemma (available free online in multiple translations).
- G. E. Moore, *Principia Ethica* (1903), Ch. 1 — the original statement of the naturalistic fallacy and the open question argument.
- John Rawls, *A Theory of Justice* (1971), §4, §9 — on the method of reflective equilibrium.
- Miranda Fricker, *Epistemic Injustice* (2007), Ch. 1 — accessible introduction to testimonial injustice.
- Richmond Campbell, 'Moral Epistemology', *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy* (2024) — the primary source for this guide.

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